

Hot or Iced?

After the lunch rush at *The Coffee Stop* was a time of absolute bliss. A red fox, dressed in the usual white shirt and black trousers of a barista, hummed a tuneless song to himself as he wiped a damp cloth over the main counter. He carefully scooped up pastry crumbs and deposited them in the bin below the counter, taking pride in the coffee shop he managed and the quiet permeating the air. The part-time crowd had gone home on weary paws, leaving Nico near enough on his own behind the counter, lithe build hardly noticeable to anyone outside the windows. Only one other employee pottered about, an older rabbit that would shortly be coming up to retirement age. Mary did not look her age, however, and Nico warranted that they would see her at *The Coffee Stop* for many more years after he had moved on.

Nico had bigger plans for his life than serving coffee day in and day out. Though young, Nico had already finished university and had his sights set on London, the bright lights of the city and bustle of life drawing him in, day by day. His degree in Marketing and Communications, joint honours, set him in good stead for many companies but it was all a waiting game, patiently keeping an eye on the job boards until a slot opened up that he could apply for. Tugging at the stud earring in his left ear, he smoothed down his russet fur, a note of sadness in his eyes.

Working at the coffee shop was all well and good in the meantime but wished it could be over already, that he could move on. There was so much more to do and he tired of patrons snarling at him for the simplest of mistakes. And, sometimes, for no mistake at all. He scowled, dark lips twisting, as he recalled the abuse of a mouse fur – so demure before she had started shouting! – whose coffee had not been made correctly, or so she said. Personally, Nico believe that she did not know the difference between a latte and a cappuccino (an easy mistake to the uninitiated) but had re-made her drink regardless and coupled it with an apology.

The fox sighed. He loathed apologising for no reason. Everything he did had a point to it.

The bell above the door tinkled and he looked up, a smile perking up his muzzle. His amber eyes were kind, if tired, as he greeted the flouncing snowy canine strutting up to the counter. His next customer of the day was a white poodle that he had seen many times before in his coffee shop, she consistently held a bored, vacant expression and left as swiftly as she entered in a brisk clack of high heels. Her fluffy ears were plumped out with specialist hair serum – a strong scent that Nico could not miss – and her short denim skirt was clearly a designer brand, matching by a baby pink shirt without sleeves and cut daringly low across the bosom. She wore different coloured contacts every time she came in but today her eyes matched her clothes in pink. He tilted his head: *how curious*.

She stopped in front of the counter and glanced between her phone and the menu above his head, making her decision with a tap-tap-tap of shocking pink painted claws against her phone. From the far end of the counter, beside the industrial coffee machines, Mary raised her head from paperwork, whiskers twitching anxiously. The poodle's eyes grazed his when she was ready and he stood to attention, one paw on the till.

“Good afternoon!” He said warmly. “How are you today?”

“Vanilla latte. Caramel shot.”

His ear twitched but he otherwise gave no indication that he had logged the snub. Tapping the drink into the till, he paused, presented with two options as her choice had not been clarified in all its entirety.

“And would you like that hot or iced today?”

Annoyance flickered in her eyes.

“I said,” she growled, “*vanilla latte. Caramel shot.*”

Nico stared at her. It was after lunch and the morning coffee crazies were long gone so why was a lunatic in his shop. As subtly as he could, he peered under her fluffed up ears, checking for a hearing aid, just in case he was being obtuse. But no, she was the one not listening to him, as far as he could see. At the other end of the counter, Mary kept her head down, though Nico had no doubt that she was giggling inwardly at his luck.

Keeping the smile fixed on his muzzle, the fox stood up straighter.

“I understand, Miss, but would you like that to be hot or iced this time?”

The poodle sighed heavily and crossed her arms over her breasts, the handbag on her shoulder jingling.

“Vanilla latte. Caramel shot.”

Nico shook his head the tiniest fraction back and forth. He did not think his incredulity could grow anymore but the poodle managed to prove him wrong at every turn. He curled one paw into a fist, claws digging and biting into his palm. What exactly was her problem anyway?

“Very well,” he muttered under his breath. “One hot latte it is.”

“What was that?”

Oh, so she was not related to a parrot after all. The bimbo poodle could talk for herself. What a surprise. Clearing his throat, Nico slid his eyes between her and the till, numbers blurring in his frustration.

“Nothing, Miss. One hot vanilla latte with a caramel shot coming right up for you!”

His customer service voice rang out as impeccably as always and he smiled genuinely, proud that he had been able to keep his composure during such an interaction. The crazy coffee drinkers wound him up on a daily basis, yet he felt he was doing exceptionally well to survive their peculiarities and, occasionally, idiocy.

The canine drummed her fingers upon the counter, making Nico’s ears twitch fervently as he reached for a paper coffee. No way was he having her hang around in the shop for any longer than was absolutely necessary!

“Make sure that’s vanilla,” she barked.

A muscle in his eyelid twitched and he busied himself with making the coffee, steaming milk in a small metal jug at the nearest coffee machine. A shot of coffee grounds sat ready to be mixed in as and when required. The fox prided himself on a job well done and could not be rivalled when it came to speed.

“Yes, a vanilla latte, no problem.”

She sighed, staring at her phone rather than the fur she was speaking to.

“And a caramel shot.”

Nico huffed with his back to her, white-tipped tail bristling. As if he had not heard her the first fucking time! Finishing up with the caramel shot, he ensured all was combined to his satisfaction and satisfied himself with not topping her drink with his perfected style of latte art. She would have to go without if she was going to be so rude about ordering a simple drink!

“Yes, no problem. All ready.”

He plopped the cup with a little more force than necessary on the counter before her and held out his paw to accept payment. The poodle glared at his paw as if it had personally insulted her and her mother.

“That’ll be three pounds fifty today, Miss.”

She dug in her tiny handbag for an inordinately long period of time before retrieving a minute hot pink purse, which she unzipped with the daintiest of tugs. Scraping together the coins into her palm, she dropped them one by one on to the counter next to Nico’s outstretched paw. She smiled as if triumphant when a few of the smaller coins tumbled too far and pinged off the other side of the counter around the fox’s hind paws. Nico’s jaw dropped but he dutifully scooped them off the counter into his paw and bent down to collect what had dropped on to the floor, anger roiling through him, red hot. Narrowing his eyes, he made no comment and settled up payment. Thankfully, there was no change to be given as he did not think he could have brought himself to touch the bitch after that little display.

“Thank you,” he said through gritted teeth. “You have a good day now.”

She spun on her heel and clacked out of the shop, coffee cup clutched smugly in one paw. The bell tinkled and she was going, prancing down the street in those silly shoes of hers, completely unsuitable for a jaunt around town. Watching her go with smouldering, snarling eyes, the fox rumbled a growl. She had gone without a brown safety to protect from the heat of the drink; Nico hoped she burned herself.

“You really do get them, don’t you?” Mary said, touching Nico’s shoulder with a gentle paw.

He slumped forward, resting his elbows on the counter as exhaustion shook his body. Sometimes, after a long day, there was one customer that pushed them too far – the straw that broke the camel’s back – and today was well and truly his day.

“Yeah,” he grumbled. “But it’s only one. I’ll live.”

“Don’t let it get to you, honey.” Mary smiled kindly. “Think of the better ones we get in here. And it’s quieter now, can get some bits and bobs done before home time.”

Nico perked up. He liked being on top of things and ensuring all was in the best shape it could be. Grabbing his cleaning supplies in both arms, he turned to the back of the shop, thinking that he could run a cloth over the tables and other surfaces, just to satisfy himself that everything was perfect.

The fox, however, did not get to the end of the counter before all hell broke loose.

“You! Fox boy!”

The door crashed open so violently that it did not have any chance to tingle. Storming back into the coffee shop, the poodle slammed the cup down on the counter and scowled, pretty muzzle twisted into the grotesque. Nico started and dropped his cleaning supplies, a spray bottle of cleaning solution skittering across the floor as he grabbed the hot cup just in time to stop it from tipping over on to its side.

She pointed at his, one manicured finger accusing in its singularity.

“You! You made my drink wrong!”

“What?” Nico was taken aback – he had heard her perfectly each time! “What’s wrong with it? Was there no caramel shot?”

She rolled her eyes and shoved the drink closer to him, slopping hot coffee over the sides of the cup and dirtying his nice, clean counter.

“What does that look like to you? Tell me.”

“I’m not quite sure how to respond to that, Miss...”

She glared at him, thunderous. Her pink eyes were especially unnerving and Nico took a step away from the counter, tail still against his legs. She lowered her muzzle threateningly, lip curling back ever so slightly to show off her sharp canines. Briefly, he considered how the expression was most unbecoming for a lady.

“What does it look like to you?”

Nico cleared his throat and glanced at Mary, who kept a watchful eye on him even though he was the manager of the little shop.

“It looks like a hot vanilla latte with a shot of caramel.”

“Yes, it is,” she growled. “It’s *hot*.”

“Yes?”

Nico raised an eyebrow. That was exactly what he had given her. A hot latte. For a moment, he considered that he may be going loopy himself.

“I want *iced*.”

He could have laughed aloud. Was that all? That was the reason for stomping back into the coffee shop as if he had spit in her drink and sprinkled tail hair on it too for good measure? But of course she had wanted it iced not hot, it was always the way. Sighing, Nico breathed a sigh of relief: that would be an easy fix. New drink and done.

“Miss, I do apologise,” the need to say so irritated Nico, “but I asked you several times if you would like it hot or iced. You merely repeated the drink that you wanted.”

“What sort of idiot makes a hot vanilla latte?” She barked, throwing her paws up in the air. “That’s ridiculous, no one ever has a hot *vanilla* latte.”

“Many furs...”

He shook his head. There was no point continuing.

“Would you like me to remake your drink, Miss?”

He reached for the cup but the poodle snatched it away from him, yanking it out of reach and dropping it on the floor at her hind paws. Coffee splattered in a brown splurge, spreading in a wave outwards as it bubbled from the cup on its side. The poodle smirked, eyes darkly cruel even through the contact lenses. Mary hurried around to the poodle’s side with wide eyes, hardly able to believe what she was seeing.

“Why bother?” The poodle huffed, paws on her hips. “You’ve ruined my day now! What are you going to do about it?”

Something in Nico snapped and there was no going back. He adjusted the collar of his shirt and cut across the poodle as she ranted, tuning her out into white noise that was neither here nor there.

“Mary, could you clean up this lady’s drink, please, while I sort out a special...beverage for her?”

Mary started and tilted her head, asking without words what on earth Nico was up to. He shook his head. He had no answer for her that she would like to hear. Mary would only stop him from what he was about to do. But every fox had his limit and the canine would see just how far she had pushed him. The canine gave a little ‘heh’, shifting her weight.

“Now, that is more like it.” The poodle huffed, considering herself triumphant. “I knew there was something special back there that you would give to *important* customers, like me. You

should have given me the right drink to begin with, then you wouldn't have to deal with this mess, boy."

Nico smiled a fox's charming smile and stepped to the side of the counter, sweeping his arm out to beckon the lady to lead the way through to the back of the shop: kitchen and storage. As if she had won a great battle, her lips curled up in a wicked, smug grin and she strode by him, heels clacking as they transferred from wood to linoleum. Cheaper flooring lined the staff only areas and Nico gave Mary a conspiring wink that she did not understand as he followed the canine's round rump into his domain. Poor little bitch: she had no idea what she was in for.

"It'll be a special drink, won't it now?"

She studied the fox critically.

"Of course. Right this way, Miss."

Stopping in the kitchen where clean glassware and china lined most surfaces, ready for the morning coffee run, she spun to face him, tapping a toe upon the ground in the most annoying rhythm.

"So? What are you going to do for me then?" She demanded, leaning forward. "It better be good."

"Oh, it will," Nico smirked.

Her fingers curled around the shoulder strap of her bag and she waited, one eyebrow expectantly raised. Nico leaned back against the dishwasher, plastic cool against the back of his trousers; the load within had been complete for a while already.

"You just going to stand there all day?" She rolled her eyes. "Sheesh. Lazy, you are, the lot of you. Bet you were a school dropout, now stuck working at a coffee shop. I almost feel sorry for you. But not really."

His eyes darkened. Oh, that was not the right way to go if she wanted an easy ride, not at all. Who was she to say that he was a dropout? From the looks of it, he was more educated than her.

"Come closer," he said.

"I'd rather not." She coughed into her paw daintily. "Foxes have a bit of a stink. I'm sure you don't realise it."

Nico moved quicker than lightning, at least to the unwary eye. Grabbing the canine by the ears, he forced her down to her knees, allowing her no cushion between them and the unyielding linoleum. His paw on her head prevented her from looking up and he took advantage of her dumbfounded moment to admire her form, if but briefly. If not for her attitude, the dog could have been pretty. He'd never caught her name. And he never would.

“What the *fuck* do you think you’re doing?” She barked, blinking stupidly as if wondering how she suddenly came to be on her knees. “*Assist* me up right this instance, fox!”

“No,” he said simply.

“What do you mean, no?”

Nico kicked the main door shut with the toe of his shoe, scuffing up polished leather. It clunked closed and locked itself, disallowing entry from the other side. Mary would wonder why he’d done it but it would not matter very soon. The fox ran his fingers through the poodle’s fur, admiring its texture, and frowned when she jerked away, half-attempting to struggle to her hind paws again, which was a tricky task indeed in the heels she was wearing.

“I think you’ve had more than enough time to talk, don’t you agree?”

While she fussed with her clothes and snarled expletives, Nico unzipped his trousers, allowing his semi-hard cock to push over the waistband of his boxers. He tucked the boxers down below his balls – out of the way for what he had in mind – and smirked, giving the shaft a few quick strokes to make himself fully hard.

It was easy to get stiff when a bitch was on her knees.

She opened her mouth to hurl further curses at him but was silenced by a warm, hot rod of flesh stuffing her muzzle. Her eyes grew wide and she gave a muffled snarl, lips curling back viciously as he pushed deeper, dragging her muzzle down on his length. Nico huffed and struggled to compose himself, fumbling his mobile phone out of his pocket and turning it on: it would shortly be needed.

The poodle yipped and clawed at his legs as if she had never learned how to fight off an assailant, paws weak in what should have been pummelling, crushing blows. Nico smirked. There was always something about a bitch in heat that made them extra compliant as much as it made them growl for the slightest reason. Only canines would be able to scent another anthro canine’s heat and hers was silent to him, except for her attitude. It was a lucky guess really that she would not fight his advances too furiously. He cupped a paw to his ear and trod on her paw, keeping her pinned to the floor before she could find reason to truly mount an attack on him.

“Hm?” He cocked his head. “What was that?”

She whined and wrapped her free paw around his calf, pupils growing as large as those belonging to a drug addict. Heat was an addiction in itself. The poodle would come to her senses, maybe, but Nico would have to move swiftly. Scratching behind her ears, he laughed as she rumbled a growl, muffled by his dick as she worked her tongue into a more comfortable position.

“Of course you agree, Miss, I knew you would. Such a kind, understanding soul you are,” he chuckled to himself. “Grumble all you want, no one will hear you in here. That door is solid.”

Teeth grazed his cock and he wagged a finger in the air, lifting the little black box of a phone cradled in his free paw. Pinching the corner of her lips, he warned her without words, hardly fearing for the safety of his cock.

“Ah-ah,” he chuckled, holding up the phone and switching it on to camera mode. “Wouldn’t want me snapping away now, would we?”

He stomped harder on her paw, feeling flesh give beneath the sole of his shoe. She whined, her eyes plaintive. Instinctively, the poodle tried to move away from the pain and found nowhere to go. Nico laughed, though there was no true mirth in the sound. He had her exactly where he wanted her.

“Then don’t try to move, bitch,” he chided. “Then it won’t hurt, will it?”

She glared at him, death lancing into his soul. It would have been terrifying to a fox like him if he did not already have her wrapped around his little finger.

“Come on now, I know you must be good at this.”

He thrust lightly into her muzzle, using its full length and nuzzling the tip right to the back of her throat. She coughed and gagged, eyes watering so that tears streamed down her muzzle until he drew back enough for her to breathe, earning himself a reproachful look. The fox chuckled and ran his claws through the fluff of her ears, admiring their sheen. She must have spent hours grooming them that morning. Thrusting again, she convulsed, arms straining to push away without putting greater pressure upon the paw still trapped beneath his shoe.

“Gagging already? Am I too big for you bitch?”

She whimpered, lips rubbing over his cock as she tried to talk. He slapped her muzzle, jerking her head to the side in a prick of teeth on his dick. She gave a muffled snarl, eyeing him reproachfully. She lifted her free paw tentatively pushing upon his thigh as if that slight action alone would get him to move, though her fear at causing herself greater pain was stark.

Frowning, he grabbed her ears and moved her muzzle forcibly along his cock, mimicking the motion of a willing bitch bobbing her muzzle on his length. Though she was not willing, the sensation would be the same and all the more delectable for putting her in her place.

“Fucking stop whining and suck it.”

She refused, shaking her head the best she could with his red length between his lips. Nico’s eyes narrowed and he looked down the length of his red muzzle at her, the knot outside her lips half-swollen with arousal. If the fox was not careful, he would spend his seed before he was good and ready.

“Obstinate? I did not think I’d have to push you. Your attempts to dislodge me have been pathetic to say the least. It’s always as if it’s natural for you to have a cock in your mouth.”

She stiffened and he took the chance to pinch her ear, drawing a hoarse yelp from her muzzle as he fucked her muzzle. Lips pressed only loosely around his cock, she whimpered and cried, crocodile tears running down her cheeks as she glared at him. The pink eyes should

have been alluring in the moment, soft in her white muzzle, but he could only see sharpness in them, a loud voice and a rough paw that spilled coffee over his clean counter. She had earned herself no mercy from him.

Huffing quietly, the fox humped her muzzle as if he was fucked her cunt, sliding over her flat, canine tongue with a shudder of pleasure. The poodle slobbered over his cock, unable to control the saliva produced with her jaw held open, as he thrust, rolling his hips forward with languid strokes. As he played with her heat, pushing her past the point where she would want to pull away, she raised her rump from the ground, tail wagging even as tears prickled continuously in the corners of her eyes. She was a bitch in need without a doubt, Nico thought, only cut off by a heady groan from his own lips.

But her blowjob was severely lacking. Well, a fox did not have to put up with that.

“Up, bitch, if you can’t suck like a whore.”

Yanking his dripping cock from her muzzle, he pulled her upright by the neck of her blouse, ignoring her hacking as she coughed. Trails of saliva hung from her lips – she had not been able to swallow while his cock strained her lips wide. It was just as well he had no plans to spill cum into her pretty little mouth after all, if she would rather gag than swallow his load.

Spinning her around, he pinned her over the dishwasher, paws stretched out in front of her body. He trapped her wrists against the plastic top, leaning his weight upon them to keep her in place as he flipped up her short skirt and rubbed his cock over her underwear-clad pussy. A pink thong. His lips twisted in a smirk. Easy enough to pull aside. As he nudged the head of his cock into her cunt, she whipped her head around, lips contorted in a vicious snarl.

“Fucking get –”

“Oh, shut up.”

He clamped his paw around her muzzle, silencing his victim. Though she could growl and whimper and make any manner of muffled noises, she could not cry out for help. Nico did not mind the whimpers and whines; they reminded him of the power he held over her, if but for a time. Power was only fleeting and he had no true will to retain it forever. She would not be worth the effort to leash.

Nico arched and thrust his full length into her, finding her dripping – even the fur on her inner thighs was sodden, her heat clouding the air. Her mind may not react to his advances but her body still did and her body wanted him to fuck her, to put a litter in her belly. Nico rocked in a thrust, revelling in the shudder that ran the full length of her body, utterly delicious in how helpless he left her. The knot grew outside her body. In a feral of his kind, it would have been locked into his partner already, swelling inside the confines of their hole.

Nico was a fox who liked a bit of force, however. And what fun was that if there was no stretch of his bitch of the night?

Smirking, he eased the knot against her pussy, grinding it over her puffy lips. She groaned into the dishwasher, muzzle turned so that her cheek was flat against it, hips shuddering. Her arse jerked up and he wrapped his paw around the base of her tail, forcing her to keep it lifted

high – the semblance of a willing bitch. The knot pressed, insistent. It was not intended to be pushed in, half-inflated. But he would have the poodle exactly as he wanted her.

“You can’t...” She mumbled, heat making her compliant.

Nico’s tail whipping the air into a frenzy, the white tip but a blur.

“Oh, I think you’ll find that I very much can.”

Leaning heavily on her paws, he thrust in savagely, popping in the knot in a manner that was never intended by nature. The poodle’s eyes went wide and she yelped a second after the pain registered, whole body quivering. Well and truly locked together, there was nothing she could do to dislodge the fox, even if she had had the strength, until he had spent himself. Dampness trickled over Nico’s crotch fur, his hips flush with her arse, but he could not have said whether it was blood or her feminine moisture. The idea of both excited him.

Hammering in with a series of short, sharp thrusts, Nico huffed, yanking on the bitch’s tail just to hear her whimper. Breath came with greater difficulty and he raced closer and closer to orgasm, the grand finale, with every thrust, arching over the poodle in triumph at his prize. Who else could say that they had taken their revenge in such a way? It was deserved, after all. As much as he deserved bone-shaking release, the canine deserved a fat knot in her cunt to satisfy her heat without the nuisance of pregnancy. Really, he was doing her a favour.

A moment before climax claimed him, the poodle jerked, twisted and yelped out in pleasure, his cock driving into that bunch of nerves inside that made her body forget that she was being raped. As he thrust, he ground her hips forward, forcing her clit against the edge of the dishwasher to rub and grind. A thrill of power tingled through his nerves and he growled, bearing down on her, breath catching and ears flicking to catch the delectable whines and grunts pushed from her lips, the poodle dazed in her own afterglow and continued pleasure.

Victory tasted as sweet as cream in his muzzle as he yipped loudly, tail curling down and balls tucking up a little closer to his body. Ecstasy seared through him like gulping down a too hot cup of coffee – pleasure overruling the discomfort of the motion. His knot seemed to grow further, larger than ever before, straining the limits of her cunt. The poodle was helpless beneath him and he moaned lowly, spending himself within her.

Their moans faded into a chorus of pants, out of time with one another, but all the same a delicate symphony. Nico nosed the back of her neck, smugness warming his chest (he would not have said his heart). The poodle did not react but to tremble, heat sated by a male’s cum for some time. She would return to her senses soon, though not for long. Only pregnancy could sate a female’s heat – Nico knew this well enough. He had helped in a way, however.

He yipped a laugh, tail wagging. Perhaps he had even helped her attitude problem some.

His knot softened more swiftly than a feral fox’s would have and he withdrew without ceremony, letting the knot pop out much as it had entered her. She slid down the dishwasher to the cool tile floor without him to support her and curled her legs up to her chest, one paw reaching below her skirt to feel cum oozing from her sore cunt. Keeping her eyes lower, she played her fingers across the engorged nub of flesh, teeth clenching as pleasure reared its

head once more. Nico may be done with her but a bitch in heat had many more ecstasies to partake in.

Nico studied her briefly, enjoying the view before he must bid adieu. Her cunt glistened with their combined sexual fluids, appearing so inviting that he suddenly wanted nothing more than to slip back within again. Creamy white cum drooled from her sex as she worked over her clit, teasing out when it should have stayed deep inside, marking her as his bitch, if temporarily. Nico bit his lip, cock swelling. Just one taste? No one would think to enter the back of the coffee shop for some time. But no, it was too risky. The fox shook himself. He had to go.

Tucking his cock back into his boxers and sorting his black trousers out, he kissed his fingertips and fluttered a wave at the bleary eyed, distracted poodle. She barely reacted, but to flick her gaze up to his muzzle and then back down to the floor again, tracing the pattern in the tiles.

Nico chuckled dryly.

“Huh,” he mused. “Looks like it was *iced* after all then.”

Groaning, she blinked up at him. One of her contacts had popped out, depicting her with one pink eye and one natural brown one. Strangely, he thought the brown was more attractive on her, though there was nothing that could be said for the ugliness of her personality. She tried a growl but the sound was cut off in her throat, painfully feeble. He blew her a kiss, turning tail out the door to the main part of the shop.

“Love you too, Miss. You have a great day now.”

He bowed deeply, somehow infusing the motion with inherent sarcasm. Leaving the canine to pick herself up, shirt torn and not fit to be worn out on the street, he buckled his belt and whistled a tune, tail swishing contentedly.

The fox strode past Mary with a cheerful wave and tossed his apron over the counter. Nico beamed as he strutted to the door, ears pricked to catch the sound of the poodle moaning. She probably had her paw between her thighs again, such a slut. He knew her kind, for all her harsh words and bitchy mannerisms. The little canine would be whimpering for his cock for weeks. Too bad she would never again have a fox like him. He held up his paw to Mary in farewell. After such a display, he would not see the rabbit again. That would be a shame but the coffee shop was long behind him.

“Mary? Let the owners know I quit, would you?”

He smirked, walking out the door for the last time on the lightest paws he had had in many months. The air seemed lighter and the sun brighter even on the edge of early winter sunset, turning the streets amber with their glow. Nico laughed aloud as the bimbo screamed behind him. Something about still not getting her coffee. There was no hope for some. But he would do fine.

So long to *The Coffee Stop*!